Women at War & The Land Army

Key Enquiry Question: How did women keep Britain running on farms, in factories, and behind the front line?

LESSON 06
KEY STAGE 2



Source A: *Land-girls resting under the shade of a tree during a harvest day in 1941, painted by Thomas Hennell. (Imperial War Museum)*

HISTORICAL READING • WHAT THIS TELLS US

With millions of young men drafted into the armed forces, Britain faced an acute labour shortage. For the first time in British history, women were called up to serve their country in industry, transport, and agriculture.

Over **80,000 volunteers** joined the Women's Land Army ("Land Girls"), working 50-hour weeks driving tractors, milking cows, and harvesting crops. Others built fighter planes, drove buses, and operated radar stations.

Task 1: Artifact Detective • Women's Land Army Recruitment

PRIMARY EVIDENCE



Source B: *1941 recruitment poster: "Come and Help with the Victory Harvest - Join the Women's Land Army", depicting a smiling Land Girl. (Ministry of Agriculture / HMSO)*

1. Look closely at Source B. How did recruitment posters persuade city women that physical farm labour in the countryside was a patriotic and rewarding duty?

2. Comparing Source A and Source B, what were the physical realities of working 50-hour weeks in mud, rain, and winter cold compared to the poster's sunny image?

Task 2: Active Chronological Challenge • Mobilising the Female Workforce

CHRONOLOGICAL UNDERSTANDING

STAGE 1 • 1939

The Volunteer Call

Young women volunteer for the Land Army. Issued green jerseys, brown breeches, and timber boots.

What would a young woman from a city office find hardest on her first week on a farm?

STAGE 2 • DEC 1941

Conscription of Women

Britain becomes the first nation to legally conscript unmarried women aged 20-30 for war industry.

Why was conscripting women seen as a revolutionary moment in British social history?

STAGE 3 • 1943

The Peak Industrial Effort

Women produce 70% of munitions, weld tank hulls, assemble Spitfires, and plot radar signals.

How did building fighter aircraft prove women were just as capable as male engineers?

Task 3: Visual Investigation • Design a Women's Land Army Armlet & Farm Duties

TACTILE INVESTIGATION

Draw and design an official Women's Land Army green service armlet featuring the official WLA crown emblem.

1. Dawn Milking (5:00 AM)
Why was rising before dawn in freezing unheated barns essential to maintain Britain's milk supply?

2. Heavy Tractor Ploughing
How did operating heavy mechanical machinery shatter old stereotypes about female physical strength?

3. The Women's Timber Corps ('Lumber Jills')
Why was felling giant trees vital to provide wooden pit props for coal mines and railways?

4. Harvesting Grain & Pest Control
Why was catching rats and gathering every ear of wheat described as frontline economic defence?

Task 4: "Thinking Heads" • Contrasting Historical Perspectives

CONTRASTING PERSPECTIVES

1 Munitions Factory Worker

What immense pressures and physical dangers do you face working 12-hour night shifts assembling explosive shells and Spitfires?

2 City Volunteer Land Girl

How has trading your comfortable London shop job for muddy boots, blistered hands, and rural farm life changed your view of yourself?

Task 5: Mission Challenge • The Decisive Home Front Army

HISTORIAN CHALLENGE

Big Question: Why could Britain not have survived, fed its population, or won the Second World War without the mass mobilization of millions of women?